1 Film

In this unit you will find out:

- how films use narrative devices, such as flashback, and camera techniques to convey meaning
- how audiences classify films by recognising their genre characteristics
- how institutions and organisations promote and regulate films
- how women are represented in films and film posters.

TALKING POINT

- Start off with an instant survey. First each person should write down their two favourite and two least favourite films.
- Now combine your chosen films into two class lists. Do the same types of films – such as adventure, fantasy, science fiction, romantic comedy and Westerns – appear on both lists? Were the same types of films popular with both boys and girls?



Genre

Did you find that it was easy to say what types of films your favourites were? If so, it is because you already know a lot about **genre**. You can also probably tell, from a few seconds of a TV trailer or even from a poster, what genre a new film is likely to be, and you will have certain expectations as a result. What film genre do these three words suggest: *Saloon*, *Sheriff*, *Gunfight*? You probably thought 'Western' before you even read the second word! Media producers rely on your ability to recognise genre when they promote new films, to arouse interest, expectation and anticipation.

ACTIVITY 1

1 Work in pairs. Make a table like the one below to show the characteristics of four popular genres: Romantic comedy, Disney animation, Science fiction and Horror.

Genre	Typical setting	Typical characters	Typical plots	Typical props	Typical themes
Romantic comedy		Young man, young woman	They meet, hate each other, coincidences throw them together ...		

2 Now share your answers with another pair. Add any good ideas that you missed.

In film, exploring the ways in which **genre characteristics** are used to create style and appeal is very important. Films are often a complex mix of genres – known as *cross-genres* or *hybrid genres* – to attract the widest possible target **audience**. For example,

KEY TERMS

Audience people who are consuming a media text

Genre a type of media text with certain predictable characteristics

Genre characteristics or **conventions** the typical features in a text which show the audience what genre it is

Toy Story (1995) seems to be a simple Disney animation aimed at children. However, it also uses the genre characteristics of:

- Science fiction – Buzz is a Space Ranger
- Westerns – Woody is a sheriff
- Adult comedy – the voices of Tom Hanks and Tim Allen deliver witty one-liners.

TIP

You can find out more about any of the films mentioned in this unit from Internet databases via Heinemann Hotlinks.

ACTIVITY 2

1 Look at the poster for *Mars Attacks!* (1996) in **1**. What genres are suggested in the poster?

2 Watch a range of film clips or film trailers. How soon can you identify what genre each one fits into, and if it demonstrates cross-genre (hybrid) characteristics? What audiences will each one attract?



1 Poster for *Mars Attacks!* (1996)

Science fiction

The roots of science fiction

Literary heritage

Science fiction is a genre that has at its heart some form of technology which is not yet possible, but which could be one day. Science fiction novels were popular long before film was even invented. Early sci-fi novels include *Twenty Thousand Leagues Under the Sea* by Jules Verne (1870) and *The Time Machine* (1895) by H G Wells.

Even earlier, Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein* was published in 1818 when she was only 21. It was the first horror/science fiction story written by a woman. It told the story of a scientist who discovers how to make a dead man live again, with terrible consequences.

Early sci-fi films

With fantastic worlds, strange technology and almost magical events, sci-fi novels offered rich material for early film-makers. Some, such as *Frankenstein*, have been

made and re-made many times as film technology has developed and offered increasingly sophisticated and realistic effects.

If you asked a group of people to draw a representation of Frankenstein's monster everybody's images would probably be very similar. This is because they are familiar with the **film archetype** representation of the monster from the first ever Frankenstein film, made in 1933 with Boris Karloff playing the monster.



Boris Karloff as Frankenstein (1933)

The social symbol sci-fi

Because science-fiction narratives often include exploration, danger and new technology, they have been used to explore issues causing concern in society.

- The Frankenstein story was used in the 1933 film to explore the fear that men and women would become so taken up by factual scientific proof that they would stop believing in God.
- American sci-fi films in the 1950s and 1960s, such as *Dr Strangelove or: How I Learned To Stop Worrying And Love The Bomb* (1964), explored the fear that nuclear technology would result in the destruction of the world.
- *Invasion of the Bodysnatchers* (1956) seemed to be about an alien invasion, but was in fact about the McCarthy trials in the 1950s, when American citizens were questioned about their possible Communist sympathies.

ACTIVITY 3 EXTENSION

If you can watch *Invasion of the Bodysnatchers*, try to find out more about the McCarthy trials and then consider how the film relates to them.

The **blockbuster** sci-fi film

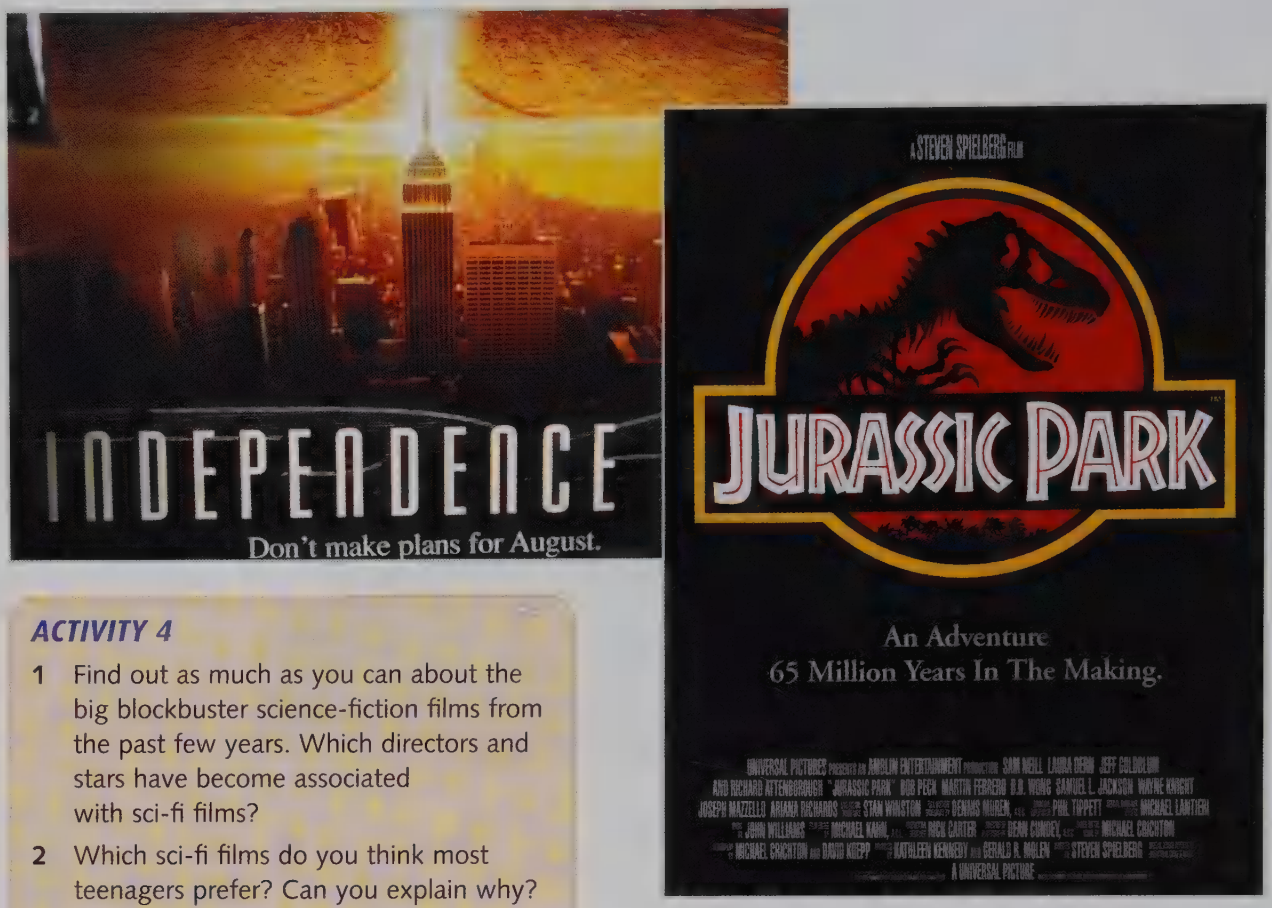
Until the early 1990s, sci-fi film was regarded as a minority genre which only longstanding fans watched. Then James Cameron produced special effects-driven *Terminator 2* in 1991, Steven Spielberg produced *Jurassic Park* in 1993 and Roland Emmerich wrote and directed *Stargate* in 1994. All these films were marketed to

KEY TERMS

Blockbuster a film expected to be a hit, so-called because of the long queues around the block to see successful films

Film archetype the outstanding features of a character, which other film-makers imitate in later films, e.g. Sean Connery as James Bond saying: 'The name's Bond. James Bond'

audiences as cross-genres of action with science fiction. With a big budget and special effects, Emmerich followed *Stargate* up in 1996 with *Independence Day*, and science fiction was established as a hugely exciting and action-packed genre for teenagers (3).



Sci-fi films became big hits in the 1990s

ACTIVITY 4

1 Find out as much as you can about the big blockbuster science-fiction films from the past few years. Which directors and stars have become associated with sci-fi films?

2 Which sci-fi films do you think most teenagers prefer? Can you explain why? Try to decide what the ingredients are that make a sci-fi film really popular.

Representations in science fiction

Representation is an important word in media studies. It means the ways in which people, places or events are *re–presented* to audiences. Representations of people are usually designed to make them as believable as possible, but if you look closely at representations of key social groups such as women, men, teenagers, ethnic groups, old people, etc. you will see that they are often quite **stereotypical**. Many teenage representations show them as being disrespectful, moody and selfish – this is obviously a very narrow view of teenagers.

ACTIVITY 5

1 Look at a range of film clips in several genres. Try to identify different ways that people are represented.

2 Make a list to show how similar social groups (women, men, teenagers, ethnic groups, old people) are generally represented.

3 Try to suggest examples of representations that are *not* stereotypical but seem to be genuinely convincing and 'realistic'.

KEY TERMS

Representation how people, places or events are represented or portrayed to audiences in media texts

Stereotypical showing groups of people in terms of certain shared and expected characteristics, e.g. showing women as nagging housewives

Propp suggested in the 1920s that every story had characters in certain roles: hero, heroine or princess, villain, donor or mentor and helper (see page 101 to find out more about these roles). Science fiction can represent groups of people in unusual ways by allowing them to fulfil unexpected roles in societies that are wholly invented.

Representations of women

Sci-fi has offered women real opportunities to be empowered and to break away from the more helpless 'princess' role. Ripley in Ridley Scott's *Alien* (1979) and Sarah Connor in *Terminator* (1984) were given lead roles who had real power and strength and were often responsible for pushing the **narrative** forward. It could be argued that such women play the hero role rather than the heroine.

ACTIVITY 6

In small groups, find out about some or all of these characters. Present your findings as a display of images with accompanying factfiles.

- Lara Croft in *Tomb Raider* (2001)
- Ripley in *Alien Resurrection* (1997)
- Princess Amidala in *Star Wars I* and *II* (1999 and 2002)
- Sarah Connor in *Terminator 2* (1991)
- Lyndsay in *The Abyss* (1989)
- Trinity in *Matrix* (1999)

Representations of aliens

One of the great conventions of sci-fi is the presence of some amazingly memorable aliens! Try jotting down as many as you can in one minute.

Sometimes taking 'human' form, sometimes robot, sometimes imaginative life-forms from other planets, aliens allow film-makers to explore different patterns of behaviour, language and customs. The essential thing about aliens is that they are *different* from us.

It is not hard to see that aliens are often used as a symbol for themes of belonging and being different. They can also be a way for film-makers to explore social problems, such as prejudice, in a subtle way.

ACTIVITY 7

1. Create your own alien. You can make it friendly or hostile, but you must label your design by pointing out key features that make it different from a human.
2. Extend your design by writing a paragraph describing how the alien responds to humans, and what would happen if it came to Earth.

ACTIVITY 8 EXTENSION

Other frequent representations in sci-fi films are: *scientists*, **stock characters** and *captains* or other leadership figures. Choose one of these representations and analyse their roles in one or two films of your choice, sharing your findings with the class as a presentation or display.

KEY TERMS

Narrative a story or account

Stock character supporting character who is often quite stereotypical and whose job it is to help the lead characters, to be saved by them or to die

Reading science-fiction films

Reading a film is similar to reading a book. First you must know the language, and then be able to work out what it means. Use this checklist to help you to look for the most important features in a sci-fi film:

- *Characters* (including aliens) will have clear roles and purposes in the narrative.
- *Costumes* are important – especially in future worlds.
- *Settings* are part of the created world and often involve **special effects**.
- *Colours* are important and are often symbolic, e.g. neon green often symbolises 'the alien'.
- *Soundtrack* is a vital clue to suggesting mood, theme and key moments.
- *Conventions* such as space, jargon, gadgets, weapons, etc. all build up the understanding of the narrative.
- *Special effects* may play a huge part – look out for animation, CGI (computer-generated imagery – see page 111), clever use of camera angles, action sequences.

KEY TERM

Special effects
exciting and dynamic visual or sound effects used to create impact in films

ACTIVITY 9

Practise your reading skills in science fiction. Watch clips from a range of sci-fi films. Make notes on the conventions, themes and characters as you go. Write your notes up as an essay or report.

ACTIVITY 10 EXTENSION

Prepare a more developed film brief (proposal), based around the following idea:

An exploration spaceship has gone missing without warning, and a crew must be sent to rescue them. Led by a female Captain and a male First Officer, the rescue ship is captured by an alien ship and taken to a new world where the inhabitants have very strange customs. The original exploration crew are also there, and the humans must work out a plan to escape and get back to Earth – but not without tragedy, love and an unexpected twist of fate before the end of the film.

1. Give your film a title and explain its meaning.
2. Cast the main parts and explain your choices.
3. Outline the narrative more fully, explaining all the interesting details.
4. Design the film poster.
5. If you are going to develop this work into a coursework piece, plan the promotion campaign for the film. This could include: storyboard or trailer, merchandise designs, soundtrack CD cover and DVD cover.



TIP

Keep your work from Activity 10 in your coursework folder.

Looking at narratives

Tzvetan Todorov devised a way of analysing narratives according to the way they move forward through different stages. He suggested that many narratives, regardless of their genre, could be broken into specific stages for analysis.

Todorov's Narrative Stages

Equilibrium – the setting is established, key character(s) are introduced and the storyline is set up.

Disruption – oppositional character(s) appear and the story takes a particular direction.

Recognition of disruption – the lives of characters and events are interwoven. Tension builds throughout this section, which is often the longest.

Attempt to repair disruption – the highest point of tension after which there is a change in dynamic.

Reinstatement of equilibrium – matters are sorted out, problems are solved and questions answered.

Emily was sick of waiting around for a wimpy prince to come and ask for her hand in marriage, so she decided to find one for herself. She soon came upon a dragon who was singeing the top of a freckle-faced boy's head.

Being a resourceful princess, Emily set a trap for the dragon and then tricked him into following her.

'You're just a silly girl, and even though it's hardly worth it, I'm going to toast you to a crisp and have you for pudding!' boomed the dragon. Just then, the branches he was standing on gave way, and he fell down a very deep well, his fire put out once and for all.

Emily returned to the boy. 'What's your name?' she asked.

'Prince Matthew,' said the boy.

'That'll do nicely,' said Emily. 'Where do you live?'

'In Happy-Ever-After,' he replied.

'That'll do nicely too,' said Emily. And with that, she and Matthew rode off together to Happy-Ever-After.



5 Emily and the dragon

Why, you may well be asking, is the children's fairy story in **5** in a book on GCSE Media Studies? The answer is that the **narrative structure** suggested by Todorov fits this story so perfectly, and there are many useful activities arising from it.

ACTIVITY 11

1 Create your own chart to show how the theory can be applied to Emily's story. The first two sections have been done to help you.

Equilibrium:	*We meet key character Emily, find out that she wants to find a prince for herself.*
Disruption:	*Emily meets oppositional characters: the dragon and boy.*
Recognition of disruption:	
Attempt to repair:	
Reinstatement:	

2 Work in a small group to find each of the stages in two films you know well.

3 Watch a short narrative – a cartoon would be a good text to use. Analyse its narrative structure by breaking it down into its five stages.

4 Think of your own simple story featuring a small boy or girl. Write a 50-word story that follows this narrative structure and read it to a partner.

Playing with narratives

Obviously not all narratives fit into the linear progression suggested by Todorov, especially if they are trying to do something different or unpredictable. For example, in the film *Back To The Future* (1985) directed by Steven Spielberg, a boy travels back in time to meet the scientist who invented time travel. The stages of the narrative in this film are not in chronological order. Can you think of any other examples?

The correct term for something that does not fit a recognised theory is a **subversion.** You may recognise these subversion techniques:

- *Flashback* – where a section of the film is referred back to, e.g. *The Hulk* (2003) directed by Ang Lee.
- *Flashforward* – where a section of the film from the future is shown before it would normally have happened, e.g. *The Matrix Reloaded* (2003) directed by the Wachowski brothers.
- *Twist* – where part of the film (often the end) is unpredictable or even shocking, e.g. *The Sixth Sense* (1999) directed by M. Night Shyamalan.
- *Parallel narratives* – where the lives of characters move alongside each other for some of the film without them meeting, e.g. *Independence Day* (1996) directed by Roland Emmerich.

KEY TERMS

Narrative structure the way in which a story is organised and shaped in terms of time and events

Oppositional characters characters who will play opposite the key central character, either in a relationship, e.g. the hero/heroine, or in conflict, e.g. the hero/villain

Subversion when a technique is used which does not fit a theory or the usual way of doing something

ACTIVITY 12

Divide into groups. Look again at Emily's story in **5**. Each group should prepare to re-tell the story, using one or more subversions. Change the original version so that the narrative no longer follows the same path. The following suggestions may help you:

- Flashback – start the story from the moment when Emily is facing the dragon.
- Flashforward – begin the story with a dream sequence in which Emily faces a fire-breathing beast.
- Twist – Emily does not have to be human!
- Parallel narratives – tell Emily's story side by side with Prince Matthew's (or the dragon's) story. This could make the audience feel differently towards them.

Audience positioning



Audiences enjoy texts most when they are really involved in them. When you analyse a media text such as a film, identify the key techniques that 'sew' the audience into it. When they are genuinely hooked into the text's narrative and development, it is as if they actually have their own position in it. You can see why this is so important – someone who is really involved in a text is much less likely to switch it off or put it back on the shelf. Here are some techniques that help an audience to become involved or positioned in a film or television text.

- **Point-of-view shots** – the camera adopts the position of a character within the text. This can be an over-the-shoulder shot, looking at whatever the character is looking at, or a shot from the point of view of the character. This is particularly powerful when the character is experiencing a strong emotion – the viewer is more likely to feel their emotion when taking their point of view.
- **Reaction shots** – the camera moves to an extreme close-up of a character's face to show their reaction to something that has happened (see **6**: Eddie Murphy in *The Nutty Professor* (1996)).



6 Reading facial expression is crucial to understanding a character's reaction

- **Insert shots** – this technique gives the audience extra or privileged information that one or more characters may not yet know, for example in a two-set scene with two characters in different locations. The audience knows what is happening to each of them when the characters themselves do not.
- **Shot reverse shot** – the camera alternates between two characters to show their building relationship (whether positive or negative), often as a conversation is taking place between them. This is a very common technique in dramas where the inter-relationship between characters is very important. The camera acts as a third person in shot reverse shot, giving the audience the impression that they are turning their heads from one character to the other.



7 These three images demonstrate the shot reverse shot technique

ACTIVITY 13

1 Watch a series of film clips from different genres. Identify as many techniques of audience positioning as possible.

2 Using a still camera, create a series of shots which demonstrate each of the audience positioning techniques. Display them in your classroom with an imaginary narrative situation written underneath each one. You can see an example in **7**.

Additional camera terms and definitions



A great deal of time is spent on setting up every scene in a film. It is important to position the cameras in just the right way to capture on film exactly what the director wants the audience to see. In addition to the techniques mentioned already, here are some other camera shots that you will be able to identify in the films you study.

Camera term	What it means
Establishing shot	The camera is set far back to show or to emphasise setting or location rather than the subject
Slo-mo	A moment which is replayed very slowly
Pan shot	The camera moves horizontally, taking in all the details along the way
Tracking shot	The camera moves alongside characters either using a hand-held technique or smooth dolly tracks
Zoom	The camera focuses in on, or out from, a subject by using a telephoto lens
Mini cam	A tiny camera is placed in an unusual place for effect
Steadi-cam	A weighted camera is strapped to an operator to allow hand-held but controlled movement

TIP

Using a chart or table to present textual analysis will help you to keep under the word limit.

ACTIVITY 14 EXTENSION

Watch the first ten minutes of one of these films: *Star Wars IV: A New Hope* (1997), *The Truman Show* (1998) or *Saving Private Ryan* (1998). Look for evidence of genre characteristics, narrative structure, audience positioning and carefully set up camerawork. Present your findings as a table, chart, report or essay.

Intertextuality

Have you ever experienced the thrill of watching a film and recognising a reference to another film? This type of link between two texts is known as an **intertextual reference**. Do you recognise the phrases 'I'll be back' and 'shaken not stirred'? Where have you heard them? Can you think of other phrases which you have heard used intertextually in films or TV programmes?

Intertextual references can be visual as well. You can find a good example of this in *Toy Story 2* (1999). The toys are riding around Al's Toy Barn in a Barbie Tour guide car and Rex the dinosaur is running behind them, his reflection clearly seen in the wing mirror. This is an intertextual reference to the scene in *Jurassic Park* (1993) when the T-Rex can be seen in the wing mirror chasing the tour guide vehicle – in this case, with the intention of eating the passengers!

Another example is the Robin Hood scene in *Shrek* (2000) when Princess Fiona fights Robin Hood and his men; she fights in the same style as Trinity from *The Matrix* (1999).

The story of *Bridget Jones Diary* (2001) is full of intertextual references to Jane Austin's *Pride and Prejudice*, although the settings and the characters of the heroines could hardly be more different. The basic storyline is similar: girl meets and hates boy but after many mishaps realises his true worth and marries him. Among other references,

KEY TERM

Intertextual reference when one media text mimics or refers to another media text in a way that many consumers will recognise

ACTIVITY 15

Play a game with a partner.

1 Each of you should choose two characters from different well known TV drama series.

2 Think of three facts about each character and give them one by one to your partner as clues, starting with the most difficult to guess. Award 5 points for guessing with just one clue, 3 for two guesses and 1 for three guesses. (You could make this a whole-class activity with rounds and a final winner.)

Analysing character can revolve around several important areas:

- The character's role in the drama
- Their relationship with other characters
- The ways that the actor brings the character to life:
  - use of voice or accent
  - movement and gesture
  - emotional power to engage with the audience.





14 Characters in soap operas become very familiar to their audiences

KEY TERMS

Central protagonists key characters around whom the text and narrative are centred

Stereotypical grouping people together according to simple shared characteristics, without allowing for any individual uniqueness

The audience can usually spot two main types of characters in a drama – those who are less important and are there for 'padding', and those around whom the main narrative(s) centre. For example, in a medical drama the people who have accidents are only shown for some of one programme, whereas the hospital staff are seen week after week. The less important characters are less developed and often more **stereotypical** than the main characters or **central protagonists** (**14**).

ACTIVITY 16

Watch a clip from any TV drama. Decide which are the less important characters and which are the central protagonists. What information did you use to help you decide?

Setting

The location of a TV drama is important in establishing a sense of a real place where the story can exist. Many regional features may well appear, such as landmarks and the local accent, dress and customs of those who live there.

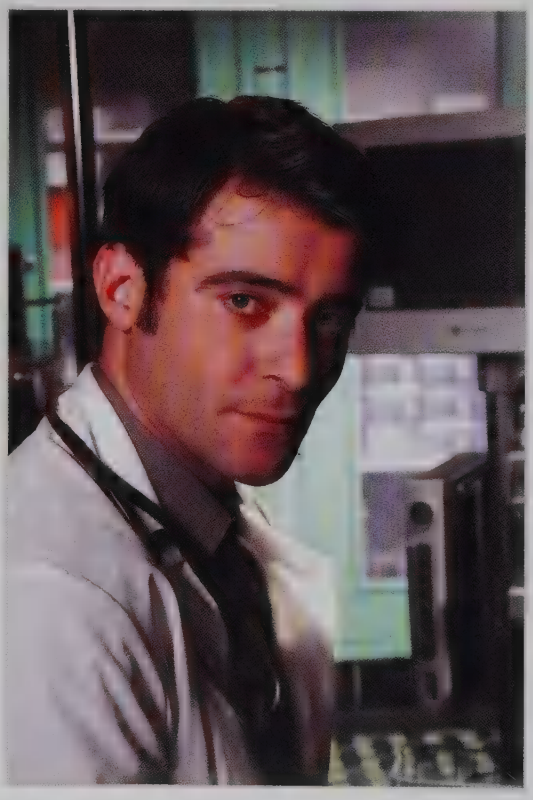
These features are included to encourage as strong a sense of engagement with the world of the drama, the characters and their lives as possible. Audiences continued to remember Dirty Den, for example, long after his exit from Albert Square because he was so perfectly set into the location and community of *EastEnders* – this also explains why his return was so well publicised. Fans of TV drama sometimes write in to their favourite characters, forgetting that they are played by actors and do not really exist.

One of the most important features of most television dramas is that they create believable or realistic worlds that audiences can watch and feel convinced by. The following case study will help you focus on just one sub-genre – the medical drama – in order to see how producers go about creating those real worlds.

Case study – medical drama

Medical drama is one of the most popular sub-genres of drama on television. It has its own set of conventions, all of which are designed to make viewers believe that the world of the programme really exists.

Medical drama developed from soap opera – serialised drama on radio and television paid for by washing powder manufacturers. It became clear that the audience for daytime soap operas – housewives at home during the day – also enjoyed dramas based in hospital wards and in doctors' surgeries. Before long soap operas appeared during peak-time viewing. Early examples included *Doctor Finlay's Casebook* and *Doctor Kildare*, which were extremely popular in the 1960s.



Two of the most popular UK medical dramas of recent years are *Casualty*, which began broadcasting on BBC1 in 1985, and its sister programme *Holby City*, also on BBC1, which began life in 1999. *ER*, on Channel 4, is an American medical drama set in Chicago that also has a large following (see **15**).

15 *ER* is a popular medical drama from the USA

Sometimes the humour is caused by the relationship between the characters – naughty children exasperating fathers or older brothers playing tricks on younger siblings. This comedy arises from the situation people are in, and is therefore called *situation comedy* or *sitcom*.

Humour also reflects people's beliefs and personalities, so they may prefer some programmes to others depending on their own experience.

ACTIVITY 22

Draw a table like the one below. Think of four more examples to add to the list, using your own experience of what you find funny.

Visual comedy	Comedy situations
Dad falls off ladder when son opens upstairs window.	*Naughty son hides school report but 'good' daughter finds it and blackmails him.*

Sitcoms and the family

The sitcom is now a television genre, but it began its life on radio in half-hour shows presenting characters in a common environment such as the workplace or the family home.

Family life has been a subject of sitcom since the early days of television. There have been many types of family represented. In the USA in the 1950s a hit sitcom *I Love Lucy* (**17**) brought to the screens a lovable yet hopeless housewife who was always getting into tricky situations that usually involved misunderstandings with her husband Ricky. The network did something unusual for the times with this live television show – they recorded it. This meant that they could show repeats and attract new audiences as the years went by.



17 Lucy and Ricky from *I Love Lucy*

ACTIVITY 23

1 Read this outline of an original *I Love Lucy* episode. How would Lucy and Ricky look and behave in a new series made for today's audiences? Think about the social changes that have taken place over the past fifty years, especially in the roles of men and women. Suggest ways to bring it up to date and think of comic complications that could happen before all is put right in the end.

Men Are Messy
Tired of cleaning up after Ricky, Lucy divides the apartment into two. He can mess up his half if he wants, but he cannot come into her half.

2 In groups, improvise some of the situations you have thought of. Vote for which you think would work best as an episode of a sitcom.

Although the types of things that go wrong that are the source of humour have not changed over time, other things have. One of the changes in society since the 1950s is that few women now are full-time housewives. Many of the plots of the *I Love Lucy* shows centred on her attempts to gain some independence, suggesting that her husband was very much the boss.

Plots in modern sitcoms still feature the battle of the sexes, but are the women stronger or weaker than the men? Read the article about the British sitcom *My Family* in **18**.



Ben is the harassed centre of the Harper family. His wife Susan is intelligent, sharp, witty and something of a control freak, and their still-loving marriage is a vehicle that may squeak but nonetheless keeps moving along. Ben – though he complains a lot – knows that he has done well in this regard. Susan works as a tour guide, Ben as a dentist, and their home life is complicated by the normal wear and tear of three children. Nick, the eldest, is a lazy, slow-witted incompetent who nonetheless has a certain charm. Janey is a stereotypical teenager, concerned with boys, fashion and looks. Michael is the youngest, a serious, studious boy arguably brighter than his brother and sister. At work, Ben is assisted by his dense hygienist Brigitte (series one) and by son Nick (series two). Janey left to go to university at the start of the third series and returned at Christmas to announce that she was pregnant.

18 *My Family*

TIP

You can find out more about *My Family* by following the links on Heinemann Hotlinks.

KEY TERM

Representation
how the media shape images of people, places and events and present them to the audience

ACTIVITY 24

Discuss these questions with a partner.

1 What do you learn about each family member in the article?
2 Which characters, from their descriptions, do you think have the most power in the Harper household?
3 What kinds of conflicts do you expect between members of the Harper family from what you have learned about their characters?
4 Why do you think sitcom is so often based on family life?

The **representation** of men, women and teenagers in sitcoms is often stereotypical.

- Men are often seen to be weaker than their female counterparts, usually their wives. They may think that they are going to get one over on them, may even look as though they are going to come out on top, but they never win and end up either losing face or losing money.
- The women are often strong characters who keep the whole family on track despite the antics of their hopeless husbands and naughty children.

Do these stereotypes also apply to sitcoms from America? The USA sitcom called *Malcolm in the Middle* also explores what life is like in a family. The narrative style, or the way the story is told, centres on the Malcolm of the title. Read his description of the family as he sees them in **19**.

ACTIVITY 25

1 What similarities are there between the families in *Malcolm in the Middle* and *My Family*?
2 Work together in groups to produce a storyline for Malcolm and his family. Write the first two minutes as a monologue for Malcolm in the style of his journal as below.

My dad's a thinker – none of us knows what about! What my mum says, goes – she's in charge of everything, even the remote control. Francis, my oldest brother, is cool – so he got kicked out. Reese, the next, is dumb, dumb, dumb. And Dewey, the youngest, was only fun until he could talk well enough to tell tales. As for me, Malcolm – well, my skin is clearing up, Reese is in high school so I don't see much of him, and life is getting better – I think!



19 *Malcolm in the Middle*

The strong mother and the exasperated father are represented here in a family situation. The family seem less middle-class than the Harpers, less wealthy and even more dysfunctional, that is, it has difficulty functioning and communicating in emotionally healthy ways.

One of the reasons for the programme's popularity was its ability to present material the audience could identify with. Everyone likes to think their family is perfect, but also knows deep down that it is not, so it is reassuring to see families on television trying to work through problems, as everyone has to do. Could it be that this type of text offers its audience a way of dealing with feelings about their concerns and fears?

Grumpy old men

Another frequent sitcom stereotype is the 'grumpy old man'. Examples from the past include the father in *Steptoe and Son* and Alf Garnett in *Till Death Us Do Part*. More recent texts include *Phoenix Nights*, *Last of the Summer Wine* and US sitcom *Becker*. How many more examples can you think of?

It could be said that in the past comedy was a way for women and children to deal with the authoritarian husband and father figure in many families. The 'grumpy old man' was not only a figure of fun, but often ultimately powerless, as behind his back his seemingly downtrodden wife quietly got her own way. Do modern sitcoms portray this situation in quite the same way? Can you think of any recent sitcoms where the 'grumpy' or 'bossy' role is filled by a woman or a young person? For example, Patty and Selma in *The Simpsons* are both grumpy. What does this say about the changes in family structure?



20 Grumpiest of them all? Victor Meldrew from *One Foot in the Grave*

ACTIVITY 26 EXTENSION

In groups, research the use of the stereotype of the grumpy old man in TV sitcom in the past 30 years. Your research resources could include the Internet, TV listings, books and interviews with older relatives about their favourite grumpy characters. Present your ideas visually and in writing for a wall display.

You need to decide whether to do your Practical Production as part of a group of up to four or on your own. For some types of practical production, such as video-making, it is virtually impossible to work alone. For the other types, group work can be helpful: two or three views and sets of ideas are likely to make for a more interesting final product. You can find more details about working in a group in the introduction.

Writing an analysis and evaluation of your work

Another difference between your GCSE production and professionally produced material is that once the editor of *Smash Hits* has published the magazine, they do not have to write an account of how good they think it is. But you do!

The analysis and evaluation (also known as a *supporting account*, *written evaluative report* or *evaluative commentary*) form a very important part of the work you will do and of your marks (see the example on page 191). If you are working in a group, it is doubly important because it will show the individual contribution you made towards the work (see pages 10–11).

The written evaluation should fall within the word count limits given by your awarding body (see pages 10–11). It should include:

- A clear opening explanation of what you were intending to produce and the target audience at whom you aimed your production.
- Some evidence that you have thought about, and preferably researched, your target audience and the 'market' for your product.
- Your own comments on the decisions that were made at each stage of production and why those decisions were made. For example, if you had three video sequences of a particular section of your film and only chose one to include in the final edit – *why* were the other two rejected? These comments on the decision-making process will be very important for your teacher when the marks are being given because it shows how much you have learnt from doing the production work.
- In a group production, a clear account of all the things you were responsible for.
- Links between your product and professionally produced work of a similar nature. How and why is yours different?
- A final evaluation of the completed production, saying how successful you think it is, what you would change if you had the chance to do it again and a statement about what you have learnt as a result of the work.
- An appendix to your written piece which includes pre-production work such as storyboards, questionnaires, scripts and work schedules.

You should *not* include:

- A string of excuses about your teacher failing to give you the right camera/computer/battery.
- A minute-by-minute account of every button that was pushed and tripod that was carried – what examiners call the 'dear Diary' approach. You only have a limited number of words, not enough to waste describing unimportant details.

Research

An important part of pre-production is the research stage. Before you rush headlong into designing your advertising campaign or shooting your pop video, you will need to think about the content of your product and the audience you are aiming it at.

Any company launching a new teen magazine in the real world would first find out about the interests and needs of the teenagers they hope to persuade to buy their magazine. They would also analyse very carefully their target audience and the products already in the market.

For some types of product you may find it useful to do some market research. This need not necessarily take the form of detailed questionnaires – though that is a possibility. But you should at the very least try out any ideas you have on some representative sample of your target audience to gauge their reaction. You should then write up what you have learnt from the research in your analysis.

Another part of your research will probably have been covered during your GCSE Media Studies course. This is a study of the way in which media texts like yours are put together. In other words, you should be familiar with the *media language* you are about to use. An important part of producing a good practical production is the extent to which you have shown your teacher and the examiner that you understand and can use effectively the *codes* and *conventions* of your chosen medium.

What does this mean in practice? Suppose you are producing a radio magazine programme aimed at a teenage market about the latest film releases. If all you do is sit down in front of a tape recorder and talk in a monotone about a few films you have seen recently, you will not have used appropriate media language. A professional programme of this sort would include interviews, extracts of dialogue from some films, and a synopsis of what the films are about and who appears in them. The presentation would be slick, with no long pauses or 'ums' and 'errs'. Usually some sort of outline script guides the way the programme develops.

Choosing your medium

With your research completed, you now need to decide which type or types of media technology you are going to use to complete your production work. Ideally you will have tried your hand at a variety of print, audio and video projects during your course so you will know your own expertise and preferences. If not, it is important as part of pre-production to practise with the type of equipment you are going to use. If you start trying to shoot a video or record a radio programme for the first time during the production phase you are less likely to do yourself full justice.

Making a video

Video is arguably the most exciting technology to use for your practical work. It is really a multi-technology because you will be dealing with pictures, sounds and maybe graphic designs too.

For these reasons it is also the most complex. To get the best results you must be sure to plan every stage in the greatest possible detail. Because there are a number of different stages and activities involved in making a video production, it is a good choice for a group. Everyone will certainly have enough chance to make their own individual contribution.

One thing you should be clear about right from the outset: small is beautiful. A thirty-second advertisement can involve a tremendous amount of hard work and planning. It is better to think in terms of a short but highly crafted video than a ten- or fifteen-minute epic. The longer the video, the less attention is paid to getting each shot as tightly composed and appropriately edited as it ought to be.

Pre-production

Storyboarding your ideas

Designing and drawing the storyboard form a vital part of the pre-production phase. A storyboard is the visual part of a film set down on paper or computer screen to look like a strip of pictures from a comic. Alongside the pictures or drawings are notes which give details of any dialogue to be spoken, any music soundtrack or sound effects, camera movements like pans or tracks, movements made by actors and sometimes notes about costume, props and, if appropriate, lighting.

Why is a storyboard important?

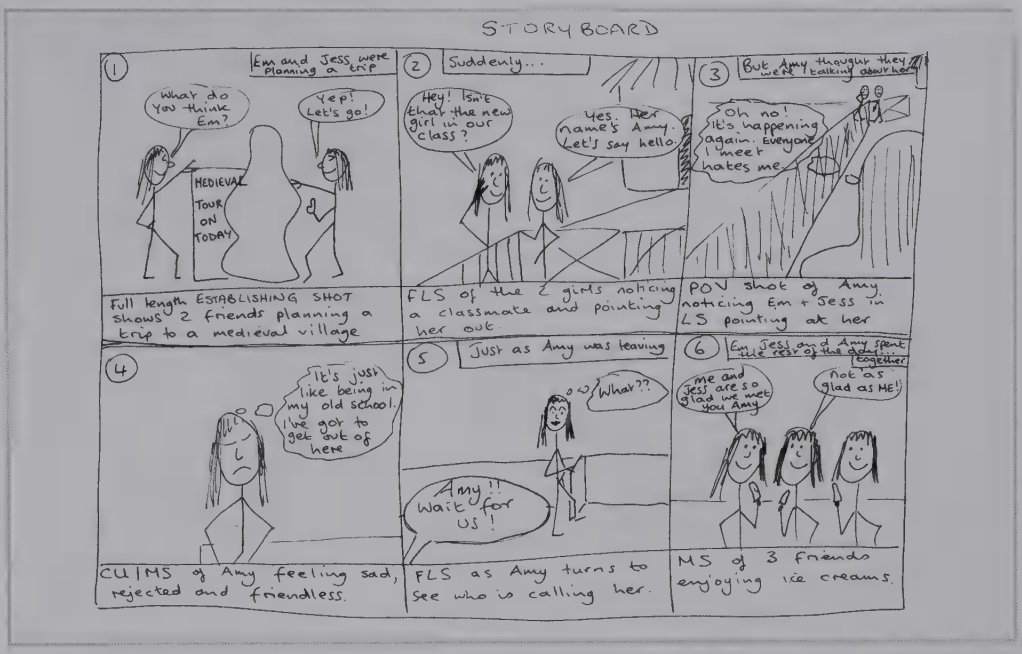
- To get visual ideas out of your head and onto paper/screen: this is often the most difficult stage of the whole filming process. Storyboarding forces you to clarify your ideas and think carefully about how to get your meaning across to the audience through pictures.
- To plan the order of the shots in a sequence: think where the camera will be placed and what movements your actors will be making.
- To save time on location: if you arrive with no idea of how the film is to be shot you will be wasting everyone's time.

Storyboarding a film

If your school has a software package such as Storyboard you can use that to storyboard your film. However, a paper version of your storyboard will do just as well. Whatever version of a storyboard you use, it should contain columns with the information shown in chart **1**.

Visuals	Shot type	Words	Music/FX	Timing
You will need to draw into this box exactly what you want the camera operator to see and film. The drawing does not need to be beautifully finished, but it must show what it is that you want to happen during the filming of this particular shot.	This is a quick back-up to your drawing in the Visuals box. It will use the common abbreviations to indicate which shot types and camera angles you wish to be used. See pages 22–24 and 39 for details of shot types.	This box will contain any words of dialogue or voice-over that accompany the shot in the visuals box.	The music is likely to run beneath a number of shots, so this column may have an arrow continuing from the boxes above showing which shots it is covering – and noting precisely which shot it begins with and at which shot it ends. The same may be true for special effects, or there may be a short noise which only occurs in this shot.	In this column show the duration of the shot or sequence.

1 How to lay out a storyboard sheet for a film



This student's completed storyboard for a photo-comic could be adapted to make a short film

Production

The production stage involves making the ideas on your storyboard into shots taken by a camera crew. You not have to shoot everything in exactly the same order as it comes on your storyboard, especially if it involves different locations. You can put things into the right order in the edit at the post-production stage.

Shot log

To save you time when you come to edit, it is a good idea always to keep a **shot log** (see the example in **3**). If you are using a sophisticated camera, you might be able to record the time code on the logging sheet, to give you an exact reference in seconds for each shot on the tape.

If, as is more likely, you are working with simpler equipment, you need to log how long the shot is and a *cumulative time*, that is, how many minutes of tape have been shot in all. This will help you find them more quickly when you come to edit. In this case it is a good idea to use a *clapper board*. All you need is a small blackboard and chalk, or a white board and marker pen. Every time you roll the camera, focus first on the clapper board on which you have written the exact shot number and take number.

TIP

If you can access *MediaStage* software, create a performance of your storyboard to refine your planning. A print out of your screen shots could be used as evidence.

KEY TERM

Shot log a list of all the shots you take in the order in which they occur on the source tape

Camera operator: JG
Camera: Canon XM 1

Location: Lydford
Date: 4th June 04

Shot no.	Set up: ELS/LS/MLS/MS/MCU/CU/ECU	Take Good (G) or No good (NG)?	Notes on shot content	Time code
1	ELS	NG	Tripod knocked	00: 31: 14
1	ELS	G	Shot down over the valley, showing village	00: 31: 27
2	LS	G	Tilt down church spire to door	00: 31: 46

Your shot log should look like this

KEY TERMS

Ambient sound the sounds of everything going on around the person who is speaking

Edit Decision List (EDL) or **Editing Script List** written statement of what is to go in the film and where it is to fit

Editor the person responsible for deciding the order in which shots and sequences are assembled at the post-production stage

Sequence a series of individual shots joined together by the editor

Synchronised sound the words spoken match the lip movements of the speaker

speaker you will pick up a lot of **ambient sound**. Sometimes you will want some ambient sound; if your actors are sitting on a beach you might want to hear the sound of waves and the wind. However, you need to control the level of those sounds so that they do not drown out the voice.

You will almost certainly need to set up shots that are no wider than a medium close-up, because the camera microphone will then be close enough to pick up a reasonable level of sound from the voice. If you are in a noisy environment, such as a busy street, you should move as close to the speaker as you reasonably can.

Using a microphone which is separate from the camera

The advantage of using an external microphone is that you can get it much closer to the person speaking while having the camera set at the type of shot you would ideally like – even if this is a long shot. Professional film crews have someone who does nothing else but record the sound. This sound recordist may use all sorts of different types of microphone, depending on the situation that is being filmed and the effect the director wants to achieve.

Post-production

The individual shots recorded during the production phase only make sense when they are joined together into **sequences**. It may help you to think of this as being like words building up into sentences. Each individual word may have some meaning. When you hear the word 'house' you have some picture in your mind of a building in which people live. But if words are added either side of it, the meaning is much clearer. 'The old house was falling down' gives you a much more detailed image to visualise. And of course if different words are put either side of 'house', the meaning is completely different: 'the glass house shimmered in the sun'. In exactly the same way, if you change the order in which your shots are combined into a sequence, the meaning can change.

Joining together the various shots into sequences is the job of the **editor**. Editing is a vitally important part of the whole film-making process. The director will very often work alongside the editor because the choices made at the editing stage can completely change the meaning of the finished piece.

Edit Decision List or Editing Script List

The first thing to do at post-production is to look at all the material you have shot and start to think about how it will all fit together. You cannot change the type of shot you or your group filmed, but for the edit you have to decide:

- how much of each shot is going to be included in the finished film
- the order in which the shots will be joined together into sequences.

When you have the basic building blocks in place, i.e. all the shots are in the right order and of the right length, then it is time to think of the finer details, such as transitions, visual effects and post-production sound.

Transitions

You get from one shot to the next by means of a *transition*. There are five main types.

- **The cut:** one shot is instantly followed on the screen by another. This is by far the most common transition. It is so common, in fact, that when it happens you hardly notice because you are so used to it.

All the other transitions are much more noticeable, so if you are thinking of using something other than a cut you should ask yourself: *What will that sort of transition add to my film that using a cut would not?*

> **TIP**
>
> If you can access *MediaStage* software, you can practise cuts and other editing techniques.

- **The jump cut:** the effect of a jump cut is to make the character on the screen appear to 'jump' from one place to another. It also makes the person watching jump because it disrupts the illusion that they are watching real life. A jump cut looks more like magic!
- **The dissolve:** the first shot gradually dissolves and is replaced by the second shot. There will be a moment when both shots are on the screen, before the first one gradually fades away.
- **The fade:** this can either be a *fade in*, which is where a blank screen is gradually filled by the incoming shot, or a *fade out* where the shot gradually fades away leaving a blank screen. The fade is usually used to show that, in the case of a fade in, a new scene is beginning, or with a fade out, that an ending of some sort has been reached.
- **The wipe:** the effect of a wipe is to see the first shot chased off the screen by the next shot. Wipes can use all sorts of different patterns to get one shot off and the next on. The incoming shot can burst through in the shape of a star or the outgoing shot can appear to swirl round and disappear like water running down a plug hole. Wipes will definitely draw attention to the fact that you are going from one shot to the next. Only use them if you have a *very* good reason.

Adding visual effects

Once again, unless there is a very good reason, avoid using too many visual effects. You should only use them when you have a clear idea of what effect you hope they will have on the viewer. Common visual effects you could use, if your editing software includes the option, include:

- desaturated colour: this gives a slightly washed out effect to the picture; you can even take out all the colour and make a black-and-white picture
- saturated colour: the colours are very vivid and unnatural
- slow motion
- fast motion.

Post-production sound

There are a few sound sources which you can think about adding to the synchronised sound you will already have recorded.

- **Voice-over sound**: this needs to be dubbed onto any picture sequences. Documentaries and advertisements often use a lot of voice-over.
- **Sound effects** will usually be added to the soundtrack at the dubbing stage. Sound effects can be further sub-divided into two types:
  - Those sounds which directly match actions or events on the screen, for example a door slamming or a glass breaking.

- Those sounds which are about the scene but do not match anything actually shown. For example, the sound of birds singing might accompany a scene set in the countryside, or traffic noise and car horns dubbed onto a scene in a city centre flat. These sound effects are called *ambient sounds*. They appear on the soundtrack to give greater depth to the illusion that what is shown is real rather than something set up to be filmed.

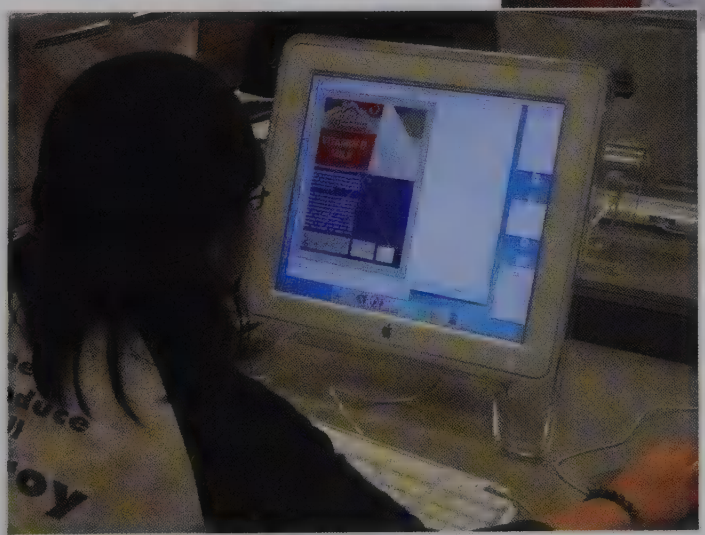
- **Music** is the final sound to be added to your film in post-production. Your choice of music will be very important. Music is used to make the audience feel certain emotions as they watch the action on screen. In high-budget film or television productions, specially composed music will be commissioned for the soundtrack. Alternatively the rights to use well known pop songs can be bought.

The rough cut

With your EDL written, you are now ready to make a *rough cut* of your film. This is a bit like a first draft of a piece of writing. You need to implement all the decisions from the EDL and then sit back and view the rough cut a few times.

Until quite recently, editing was a very time-consuming business, mainly because any changes meant starting from the beginning and editing everything again. With new digital software packages that are cheap and easily available, editing can really become a drafting process.





7 Stages in the production of a video

It is not possible here to give detailed instructions about the process of using editing software because this will be different from one package to the next. If you are not familiar with the way the software works you will need to explore it before beginning your rough cut.

When viewing your rough cut, you need to think about these factors, and write about them in your analysis.

- **The length of time each shot is held on screen:** It is only when you see your rough cut that you will know whether your EDL got this right. If a shot contains one line spoken to camera by your actor then it cannot be shorter than the actual words being delivered. But is there a half-second pause that you could get rid of at the beginning to make the sequence flow more smoothly? Or does the shot end much too abruptly? Maybe an extra half second would make it less rushed? Remember – you can work as exactly as one twenty-fourth of a second so it pays to get the length of shot exactly right.
- **The order in which the shots occur:** Although you may have thought the order was correct when you were writing your EDL, on viewing them you may find that you can change them around, or even lose some altogether.
- **How well any visual effects, music or sound you have added work:** Does the music create the right mood for your film? Are the slow-motion sequences too slow or not slow enough? Do not be afraid to change things and see if they can be made to work more effectively – that is why you made a rough cut.
- **Have you got titles and end credits right?** Often you can leave the design of a title sequence until after you have viewed the rough. The same will be true for the end credits. But you will need to make sure everyone who has worked on or helped in the making of your film gets a mention.

The fine cut

Now that you have made all the notes on the changes to be made, you are ready to return to the editing software and make the final version – the fine cut – of your film.

Making a radio programme

In comparison to video-making, recording an audio product is potentially a much simpler process. It is possible to produce almost broadcast-quality results with relatively inexpensive equipment.

The type of recording gear you use will probably be dictated by the resources your school can provide. These days most radio stations use digital equipment, so interviews will be recorded on mini-disc players which slip into a journalist's coat pocket. But not long ago they were still recording on audio cassettes or open spool tape. Even if you only have access to audio-cassette machines, you can still make a radio programme which sounds pretty much like the real thing.

Pre-production

Once you have completed your research you will need to write a programme outline and then a running order of the items which are to appear. It is important to show that you can use a full range of audio sources. Making a 'top ten' music hits tape, with you as the DJ, may be easy but it will not challenge you very much. If you are making a radio programme you should think about a 5–10-minute section of a radio-style

Using thirds

Where will you place significant elements in your picture? Research has shown that viewers look first at the human face – especially the eyes – and any points of high contrast. Photographers often talk about the *principle of thirds*. When looking through the viewfinders of their cameras, they imagine a grid formed by two vertical and two horizontal lines which divide the picture into thirds. They then place key elements of the composition, often using a one-third to two-thirds proportion. Look at photograph **10** and think about the way it has used thirds for its composition.



10 This photo was composed using the principle of thirds

Lines of movement

Photographs are often thought to have a stronger composition if the objects in them are seen as 'moving into' the picture – see **11**.



11 The men are looking into the right of this frame

Diagonals and horizontals

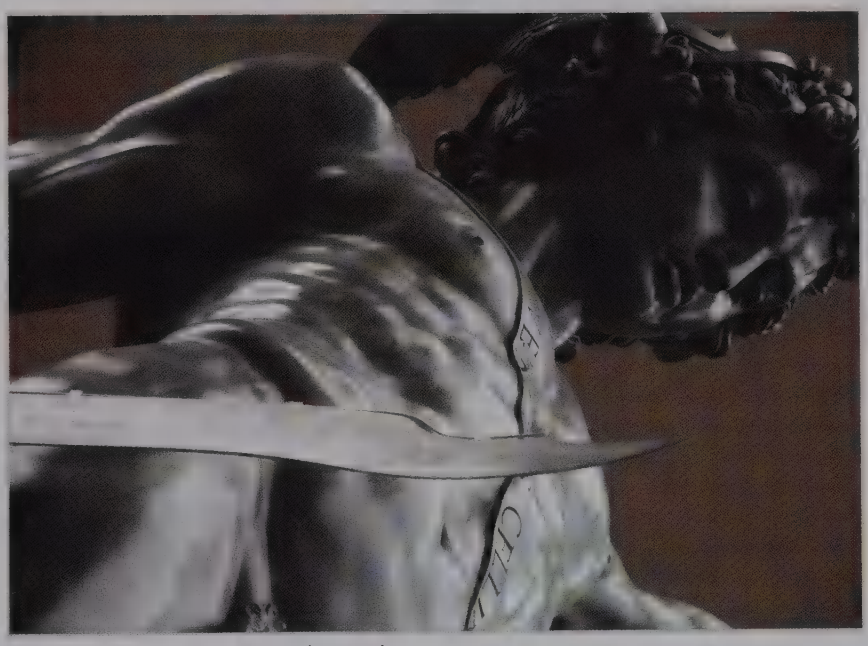
Diagonal lines in compositions are said to be more dynamic than horizontal ones. How have lines been used in the composition in image **12**?



12 St Marks Square, Venice

Angle

Most photographs are taken at eye level. Taking them from above or below, as in **13**, your subject can be another way of creating visual impact.



13 This photo was taken from a low angle

Light

Getting the lighting right can mean more than just making sure there is enough light. The factors mentioned for video production on page 175 apply equally to lighting for a still photograph. Strong sunlight coming through the overhead railway in Brooklyn adds to the composition of photograph **14**.